

So you're thinking about design

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We'll be straight with you, because you'll find this out anyway and you'd rather hear it properly than in fragments.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. **Production and execution design came out at 8.4 out of 10 — the highest score of anything we measured.**

Creative direction scored 5.6. UX and product design 6.0.

So the field didn't collapse. It split — and which side you aim at matters more here than in any other career we looked at.

The 60-second version

- Making assets is the most automated professional work in this index.
- Direction, UX and product design are real, growing, well-paid careers.
- **The US government already counts them as two separate jobs — one shrinking, one growing 7%.**
- The route from production up to direction is the part that broke.
- Which means you aim at the protected end from the start, rather than assuming you'll get there.

Why this one is different

Here's the thing that makes design unlike every other career we scored, and it's worth understanding properly.

In nursing, AI took the charting. In medicine, the note-writing. In teaching, the marking. In law, document review.

In every one of those, the automated part was the bit people resented. Automation gave them back the job they actually trained for.

In design, the automated part is the craft.

Making the image. Building the layout. Producing the thing. That wasn't the admin around design — it was design. It's what you spend years learning to do well.

We rate it 9.1 out of 10 on "how much can AI already do" — the highest rating we give any factor for any career. Not because the profession is worthless, but because **the specific thing most**

designers spend most of their day doing is now something a non-designer can do adequately in seconds.

That lands differently from "your paperwork is automated," and pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

The proof isn't ours

You don't have to take our word for the split. The US Bureau of Labor Statistics already counts these as two different jobs:

BLS CATEGORY	PROJECTED GROWTH	PAY
Graphic Designers	+2% — slower than average	median \$61,300
Web & Digital Interface Designers (UX, UI, product)	+7% — much faster than average	roughly 60% higher

Same underlying skills. Different category. Triple the growth and a substantial pay premium.

And the BLS says it directly in its own outlook: *automated design tools, such as artificial intelligence, may reduce the need for companies to contract with freelance graphic designers.*

Government statistical agencies don't usually name a technology as a headwind for a specific job. That they did here tells you something.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Creative direction / brand	5.6
UX / product design	6.0
Motion, 3D & technical craft	7.0
Illustration / commercial art	7.5
Production / execution design	8.4

The pattern: deciding is protected, producing isn't.

What we won't soften

The way up has broken. You used to start in production, make a lot of mediocre work, get told why it was mediocre, and slowly build taste. Then you got to direct.

That first rung is the automated part now. So the ladder's top is intact and its bottom is gone, and nobody has built a replacement.

Your portfolio needs to change. Volume of polished work used to be the signal. Volume is free now, so a portfolio full of beautiful assets says almost nothing. What signals value is evidence of judgment — what the problem was, what you rejected, why, and what happened when it shipped.

And the pricing model is under real strain. Design was sold by time or by asset. When an asset takes minutes, that breaks. The profession is currently rebuilding how it charges.

The genuinely good news

Nearly 40% of companies now use AI to start creative projects — but only 14% of hiring managers expect to need fewer freelance designers.

That's from a 2026 study run by Fast Company with AIGA across 1,426 people, including 153 companies that actually hire designers.

It suggests AI is being used at the start of the process rather than instead of it. It's a forecast rather than an observed outcome, so treat it as encouraging rather than settled — but it's the best evidence available and it points the right way.

Also true: creative directors report a median around \$138,000. Specialists out-earn generalists substantially. And about one in five designers is self-employed, which is high, and the autonomy is real.

The question that actually decides this

Do you love the making, or do you love the problem?

This is genuinely diagnostic, and it's worth being honest with yourself rather than giving the answer that sounds better.

If it's the *making* — the craft, the satisfaction of building something beautiful with your hands and your software — then the honest news is that this is the part under most pressure. That's not a reason to stop. It is a reason to know it.

If it's the *problem* — working out what should exist, why this and not that, how to make someone understand something — then you're already oriented at the protected end, and that end is real.

Most people are some of both. Which one leads matters.

What to aim at instead

UX and product design. Same instincts, materially better position, and the category the government projects growing. If any part of you finds the research and problem-framing side interesting, look here first.

Direction and brand. Taste, intent, and being answerable for the choice. Harder to reach from a standing start, which is exactly why aiming at it early matters.

Design plus a domain — healthcare, accessibility, industrial design. The domain is the protection.

Or craft where the physical object is the point — print, signage, furniture, ceramics. Physical protection reappears there, and it's a genuinely different score.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Is it built around concept or around software?** A curriculum organised by tool is training you for the automated tier. One organised around brief, rationale and critique isn't.
- **How much critique do you get, and how rigorous?** Defending your decisions is the protected skill.
- **Is there a UX or product pathway?** Given the category split, this matters more than the school's reputation.
- **Real client work** with actual constraints.

- **What job titles do graduates have at six months?** Not "working in the creative industries."
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Two things worth doing

Get a real brief. A small business, a charity, a school project with an actual client and actual constraints. Real briefs teach you what studio projects can't — mainly that the answer is usually a business problem in disguise.

Then find a designer two or three years in and ask what they actually do all day, and what's changed in the last eighteen months. Their answer will be more current than anything written down, including this.

One last thing

If someone has already told you design is a bad idea, they were half right and probably not helpful about it.

The path is narrower than it was. It hasn't closed.

And here's the part that matters: the judgment about what should exist is now worth more than the ability to make it — and that judgment gets built by people who care about craft. Not by people who never did.

You just have to aim at the deciding end deliberately, rather than assuming you'll drift there the way people used to.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **Graphic Designers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — read this, then read the **Web and Digital Interface Designers** page next to it. The difference between those two pages is the most useful thing in this whole document.
- **Freelance design in 2026** — Fast Company with AIGA, 1,426 designers and hiring managers. The clearest picture of what's actually happening to design work and pricing.
- **Is graphic design a good career in 2026?** — a careful walk through the BLS category split. It's published by a design college, so read the framing critically, but the data is cited

properly.

There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.